

who 'took yoga to the West', laugh sadly.

One of them, a highly respected teacher now in his 90s, was sitting in a sea of white cushions at his India-based institute, talking of his journey with yoga. He folded in, left over right, Yin over Yang, symmetrical, balanced, bent into a flower, a lotus. He looked up, his hands in the lap of his padmasana. "Now I find myself wondering if it was such a good idea to carry yoga to the West as I and others did at that time," he said. "Now it is so much about it being a fashion." A hand lifted out of his lap and he opened his fingers, feeling for a

clever, but it is not yoga."

In the US, Bikram Choudhury, the man behind Bikram yoga, a practice done at 105°F (40.5°C), otherwise known as hot yoga, has not only copyrighted the 27 postures that he claims are his alone, but he and his wife Rajashree are encouraging yoga competitions in the US, with the ultimate aim of having yoga included as an Olympic sport. Choudhury's Yoga College of India in the US has churned out thousands of Bikram teachers. The eight-week course that costs \$10,000 and offers *ashram*-life, Bikram-style, is very different from the life of *satsang* and *aarti* in those that line the river Ganga in Rishikesh. The next teacher training starts in April 2010 and will be held at the Las Vegas Hilton. Those who giggle about the methods adopted by the international corporate yoga super-league are told that this is simply an adaptation of the ancient system to the modern world. The Las Vegas brigade will say that the sniggering purists are being judgemental, and that is surely a sign that they are not yoga practitioners. It is a game, one school slagging off another, each claiming their superiority as the one true method.

Here in India Sri Sri Ravi Shankar launched The Art of Living in 1981 as a stress elimination programme. This man, who is referred to by his followers as His Holiness, bases his workshops around what he calls his breathing method, the sudarshan kriya, dubbed as 'a powerful revitalising breathing technique gifted to the world by His Holiness Sri Sri Ravi Shankar after spending 10 days in deep contemplation, and silence'. The kernel of this breathing and cleansing method is the idea that every emotion has a matching breath, and that the specific rhythm of the sudarshan kriya allows both the body and mind to release stress, and so come into the present moment. He has launched a conflict resolution project, and one for disaster relief. As with those whose path he follows, most particularly Mahatma Gandhi, Sri Sri is rooted in the belief that love and wisdom will prevail over hatred and distress. While his followers claim that he has reached 300 million people worldwide with his teaching and methods, his critics claim that The Art of Living is a programme that targets the more affluent middle class, particularly

simile. "Like a shoe, now it fits, this week, this month, maybe this year, maybe next year too, it fits, but then? I see people practising, practising all over the West. They practise hard you know, makes us Indians look so lazy," he laughed. "You know there is even a thing now called 'rock yoga' with all the boom, boom like you have on the beaches in Goa?" He closed his eyes. "Very clever you know, and they are doing amazing things." He stopped for a moment before nodding his head. "Yes, very



AP PHOTO

In Search of NIRVANA

2002 Aastha TV launched in Asia, Africa, Australia and Europe. It now reaches over 30 million households, with a viewership of about 200 million worldwide.

2003 Mother Teresa is beatified as the Blessed Teresa of Calcutta.

2004 The BBC airs a documentary, *The Secret Swami*, where aspersions are cast on Sri Sathya Sai Baba's coercive sexual relations with young boys.

2005 Renowned yoga teacher BKS Iyengar goes to the US to promote his book, *Light on Life*. He also conducts a special workshop at the Yoga Journal Conference in Colorado.

2006 Brinda Karat accuses Ramdev of violating labour laws.

2008 Controversy strikes when two boys are killed at Asaram Bapu's ashram in Chhindwara.

BUSINESS AND SPIRITUALITY move in opposite directions. In business, you give less and take more. In spirituality, you give more and take less.

SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR, SPIRITUAL GURU